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From the editor-in-chief

Everyone knows that India's doctors are the most sought after the world over and we have long heard about the mushrooming of "medical tourism" in our leading hospitals. But in the last decade, a growing, wealthier, 200-million-strong middle class is demanding world-standard quality in healthcare and is willing to pay for it. Whether it is in diagnostics, high technology or basic hospital services, urban India will no longer put up with shabby wards, outdated machines and endless delays. Deteriorating standards and the crush of numbers in public health facilities are driving an increasing number of Indians to seek different options.

This has encouraged new players from the private sector to get into the healthcare business and those who are already in it to upgrade or expand their facilities to offer better care. India is one of the largest healthcare markets in the world. It is estimated to be worth close to Rs 200,000 crore. The private sector controls 80 per cent of this and runs 60 per cent of India's 15,393 hospitals.

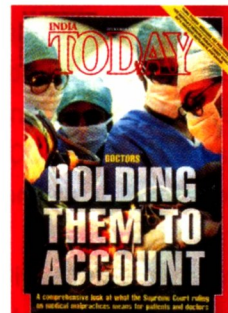
It is these numbers that are leading to the new wave in India's healthcare sector. It may not be as celebrated as our telecom, software or automobile industries, but according to a recent study, it is growing at the rate of 16 per cent per annum. In some of the major metros, India is close to the global benchmark of 35 beds per 10,000 people. What adds more muscle to the industry is the increase of medical insurance to more people and the amount of investment that private equity investors are willing to put into expanding hospital numbers.

The sector seems immune to the global meltdown. This year, about 15 major hospital projects with a total investment worth Rs 3,415 crore are expected to be launched. Across all regions there are sweeping changes taking place. There is now a trend of creating medicities which is a concept of integrating super speciality hospitals under one management. Many of the plans are audacious as they should be to meet the country's future health needs. It is, however, easier to make the buildings and install the equipment than to find the able doctors, nurses and trained technicians to deliver better healthcare. Over the next two decades, India will need twice as many doctors, three times as many nurses and four times as many paramedics it has now. After all, in the end the quality of care will depend on the competence of the medical professionals who come in contact with the patient regardless of how fancy the buildings may be. The Government too must improve the quality of public healthcare so that the disadvantaged in our society don't get left behind. If India is to progress, a healthy India is a must.

Our cover story this week is an in-depth look at the boom in India's healthcare and was written by Deputy Editor Damayanti Datta who spoke to a range of doctors, healthcare professionals and investors. She says, "Many things in this boom came as a surprise, most of all the fact that hospital planning and design came up in a big way only a few years ago."

A healthcare revolution is taking place in India. The new age Indian hospital now offers patients a clean environment, fewer queues and quality care along with the latest global equipment and drugs. No one likes going to hospital. But when there is no other option, the patient has been given several, high-quality choices for the first time in India.

(Aroon Purie)



OUR DECEMBER
1995 COVER



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